If this strategy seems abstract, think about how authorization works in Google Docs. When you share a document with a colleague, you can decide whether they are a viewer, commenter, or editor. You don't assign them a role in a central system—you give access based on your relationship with that document. Under the hood, Google uses a ReBAC system called Zanzibar to enforce this model. Zanzibar (https://research.google/pubs/zanzibar-googles-consistent-global-authorization-system/) is a highly scalable authorization system that determines access through a graph of relationships among users, resources, and permissions. It supports authorization for various Google products, including Docs, Drive, Calendar, and more.

Zanzibar has sparked a wave of modern ReBAC systems—from open-source projects like Authzed (https://authzed.com) and OpenFGA (https://openfga.dev) to enterprise solutions built by companies like Airbnb, Carta, and Intuit. What they all have in common is a graph-based method for access control: principals and resources are represented as nodes, with the connections between them defining permissions and justifications.

ACME Corp adopted ReBAC as part of a new Customer Collaboration Platform designed to enhance how employees and customers work together. This system manages access to content like support tickets, deployment plans, and other shared documents. Employees such as support engineers, solution architects, and account managers interact directly with customers and need to control who can see what based on their relationships.

To support this model, ACME represents employees, customers, and documents as nodes in a graph, and defines edges based on roles and responsibilities. For example:

- Jack and Kate are ACME Corp customers.
- Bob is a support engineer assigned to ticket #456 as an editor.
- Bob is one of Kate's support engineers.
- Alice, Jack's solution architect, owns a deployment plan that Jack can view.
- Carol manages Alice and Bob.